

HongKong 2019's Protests :

A typical example of the use of digital tools during social protest

BENAMAR Yassine, JAFFUEL Romain

November 2025

<i>Background overview of the region's situation.....</i>	<i>1</i>
<i>Method and Research Question.....</i>	<i>2</i>
<i>Case Study Analysis.....</i>	<i>2</i>
<i>Conclusion.....</i>	<i>4</i>
<i>References.....</i>	<i>5</i>

Background overview of the region's situation

Ever since the retrocession of the British colony of Hong Kong to the People's Republic of China in 1997, the special administrative region of Hong Kong has been the theatre of clashes between two opposite political cultures ; the Chinese government's line and the autonomous democratic Hong Kongese vision.

Although the successive regionwide protests that took place there are related to various political and legal issues, the underlying matters remained the same : the struggle of the Hong Kongese people to obtain and protect a healthy and autonomous democracy that will defend their human rights through a rule of law.

These political wishes conflict with the centralist and authoritarian vision of the Chinese government that considers itself righteous to govern the region, as Hong Kong owes its special status to its colonial background that is different from the Qing Dynasty's.

Despite the fact that there are two major protests in Hong Kong's recent history where media and online platforms' role became prominent in both side's strategies, we will focus on the 2019's protest, as it is, to some extent, the extension of the 2014's Umbrella failed movement, and the one where the use of social medias has been central in both organising and countering the protests, and influencing the narrative around the events for both sides.

In 2019, prior to the beginning of the protests, the Great Firewall wasn't fully deployed in Hong Kong, allowing Hong Kongese to use worldwidely used online platforms such as Telegram and YouTube, Chinese controlled ones such as Weixin and Weibo, and

local platforms such as LIHKG. All three of these geographical layers will have their significant impact during the protests and their analysis will be further elaborated in the case study.

The protests firing incident was the introduction of a bill to allow extradition of Hong Kongese to mainland China and Taiwan. This bill was introduced after a femicide perpetrated by a Hong Kongese young adult on his pregnant girlfriend during their vacations in Taipei. The Hong Kongese justice couldn't judge him for a crime, although serious, committed outside of Hong Kong's jurisdiction, plus they weren't allowed to extradite him as there was no extradition agreement allowing it.

Whereas this bill could have brought the authors of serious offenses to justice, it would also put at risk every Hong Kongese opposing Beijing's political views. As the PRC has in its disposal several legal ways to harm freedom of speech and freedom of assembly, this bill is a direct threat to human rights.

Literature on the topic already discusses how China embodies the typical actor of Digital Authoritarianism (Bohra, 2023), and what role can social medias play during protests (Della Porta, 2018). In the following study, we will focus on how these concepts apply to the specific case of the Hong Kong's 2019 protests.

Method and Research Question

Hong Kong 2019's protests are well documented from every stakeholder involved. Apart from the chronological events and the political responses from the state, the use of digital tools is well recorded, as existing resources are still openable and removed ones are still accessible (on websites such as WayBackMachine). Moreover, as both sides were actively documenting their own activities and commenting on the other side's, we can easily access their point of views.

Thus, during our research, we made sure to take into account both side's content, whether official newspapers or officious discussions. Several authorities sources were in mandarin and a few Hong Kongese ones were in cantonese, as we could have expected, we had to rely on translations or summaries of these resources on other ones. It is important to note that this topic is still sensitive as it is very recent, and the techniques deployed during it are new, thus literature still needs more time to refine. Moreover, Hong Kongese are still under heavy surveillance and online content concerning this topic are still monitored by Chinese authorities, whether it is content shared during the protests or newer content.

Case Study Analysis

Digital Authoritarianism is the use of digital information technology by authoritarian regimes to surveil, repress, and manipulate domestic and foreign populations (Bohrat, 2023). In the following part, we will see how China's methods match this definition.

Firstly, like mainland China, Hong Kong's infrastructure incorporates a wide range of surveillance technologies in public areas, such as facial recognition through CCTV installations. This allows the government to identify citizens, which is a threat to their right to privacy.

Secondly, both Western and Hong Kongese press reported systematic use of violence against protesters, whether peaceful or violent (Pubrick, 2019), despising their freedom of assembly.

Furthermore, the National Security Law passed in 2020 allowed arrests for “seditious online speech”, depriving protesters of their freedom of speech, both online and offline.

In this context, online platforms become the very core of inclusive discussions on the movement’s goals, means, next moves, etc. But as part of these debates took place on Western social medias, foreign actors played an important role in shaping the narrative around the protests. Twitter and Facebook restrained the activity of several hundreds of accounts, allegedly located within China, stating that they were sowing political discord in Hong Kong.

The use of platforms by the protesters quickly became central (Li, 2025). The Hong Kongese online forum LIHKG, created in 2016, hosted citizen-initiated polls and threads to discuss the movement’s thoughts and decisions. Parallely to social networks, newspapers were massively relaying protest actions and other related news. Pro-democracy ones, such as Apple Daily, who later fell under the 2020’s National Security Law, were massively used ; estimated up to 86.000 unique monthly Hong Kongese visitors (Yu, 2021). However, both sides of the event are accused of misinformation, polarising more and more opinions and instrumentalising scare (Wong, 2020) (RTHK, 2019).

The concepts theorized by Porta & al in 2018 “The nexus between media, communication and social movements” help us to better understand the dynamics behind the Hong Kong protests; they occurred inside a hybrid media context, where citizens were simultaneously using both Chinese and Hong Kongese platforms and social networks, and foreign ones.

First, as Hong Kongese phone numbers are processed in the Chinese servers of Weixin, and not in its international equivalent (servers outside of China) WeChat, Chinese authorities were using their control over this nationally adopted app to delete pro-protests content and track their senders (Weixin Privacy Protection Guidelines, 2019).

Second, as the Great Firewall (the Chinese massive networking infrastructure isolating mainland China’s internet from the rest of the world) isn’t fully effective in Hong Kong, citizens have access to outside services such as foreign instant messaging applications like Telegram, whose privacy policy claims that only senders and receivers can access discussion’s content. Protesters have used it anonymously in very large group chats to organise the details of the protests and share updates about the movement. However, anonymity prevents other users from holding someone liable for what he shares. Thus, both sides have used this feature to propagate allegedly fake news during the protests ; protesters spread conspiracy theories (Pao, 2019) and authorities would display screenshots of chats where protesters allegedly planned on a terrorist attack (Zheng, 2019).

Digital platforms helped coordinate large groups quickly and at low costs. This was used by the protesters with the “Be Water” technique, in which they quickly moved their location when the police arrived. This organisation model perfectly fits Porta’s “E-governance” concept of an offline movement organised online, using platforms and message applications.

The protests ended with the COVID-19 crisis. The Congress of the PRC unanimously passed the 2020 Hong Kong National Security Law. This law introduces four crimes: secession, subversion, terrorism and collusion with a foreign organisation (Cheng, 2021). Secession crime includes open speech in favor of the independence of Hong Kong from China. To apply this law, authorities have the right to surveil suspected citizens and to force any online service provider to restrict online content. After June 2020, in the six months after the NSL became effective, at least 100 individuals were arrested based on the new law, 24 of them

involved charges related to “seditious” or “secessionist” speech. The NSL reduces some fundamental rights, such as freedom of expression, the right to privacy.

In a 2022 research paper, Wang & Mayer showed, using the history of tweets of Hong Kongese, that the users tend to remove their past online activity. This reveals the concerns of the citizens about being persecuted for their previous online activities. They also observed that Hong Kong users post less often about politically sensitive topics that are censored on social media by Beijing’s authorities than before the law. This enlightens the self-censorship that has occurred since 2020.

Conclusion

The 2019 Hong Kong protests highlight how digital tools and digital behaviors can influence the organisation of the movement and a government’s response. Protesters used platforms for different purposes: local forums like LIHKG to discuss ideas and vote on decisions, foreign applications like Telegram to coordinate in real time, and newspapers to follow the evolution of the situation. At the same time, China and Hong Kong authorities used digital technologies to monitor online discussions, identify protesters, remove content and influence the narrative about the events.

This shaped a discursive opportunity structure surrounding the movement: Western media generally contributed to legitimising protesters’ claims. In contrast, Chinese state-controlled media produced a hostile speech that framed the protesters as destabilising and violent. After the adoption of the National Security Law in 2020, online expression became much more risky. Many Hong Kong users deleted old posts and stopped writing about politically sensitive topics, showing the rise of self-censorship.

This highlights how digital infrastructure and fights over its control can directly impact struggles for human rights, both for those who are to be enjoyed virtually, such as freedom of speech, and those who happen in real life, as activity online can lead to physical arrests of protesters.

References

- Bhorat, Z., & Rauchbauer, M. (2023). *Decoding digital authoritarianism*. Global Affairs Canada.
- Lee, F. L. F., Liang, H., Cheng, E. W., Tang, G. K. Y., & Yuen, S. (2022). Affordances, movement dynamics, and a centralized digital communication platform in a networked movement. *Information, Communication & Society*, 25(12), 1699–1716.
- Li, Y. (2025). Digital organizers in Hong Kong: The challenges of movement organizing through social media amid democratic backsliding. *Social Media + Society*.
- Porta, D. della, & Pavan, E. (2018). The nexus between media, communication and social movements: Looking back and the way forward. In L. Stein, S. Kidd, & T. Hochuli (Eds.), *The Routledge companion to media and activism*. Routledge.
- Purbrick, M. (2019). A report of the 2019 Hong Kong protests. *Asian Affairs*, 50(4), 465–487.
- Shao, G. (2019). Social media has become a battleground in Hong Kong's protests. *CNBC*.
- Twitter Safety. (2019, August 19). *Information operations directed at Hong Kong*. X/Twitter.
- "Head of prosecutors' group accuses police of lying". RTHK. 2019-09-02.
- "Weixin Privacy Protection Guidelines". weixin.qq.com. 2020-09-09